CHINA UNFOLD

China Unfold



A deeper journey.

The illustrated China travel reference. Places, people and practical details for a journey that feels like you.

COMPLIMENTARY EDITORIAL PREVIEW

A country to discover.

Begin with a place that speaks to you. These chapters are introductions, with practical prompts to help you plan more deeply.

Beijing	North	4
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A little preparation.

Check entry requirements

Confirm requirements for your passport, route and stay with the official authorities before buying non-refundable travel. Hong Kong and Macao have separate entry arrangements.

Official reference

Keep the arrival details offline

Save your accommodation address in Chinese, reservation confirmations, first transfer, insurance details and emergency contacts. Carry more than one way to pay.

Official reference

Think door to door

Check the exact station and airport on each ticket. Leave time for local transfers, security, check-in and rest. A train journey is only one part of a travel day.

Official reference

Travel thoughtfully

Ask before photographing people. Follow local guidance at temples and museums. For food allergies, carry a carefully translated explanation and confirm ingredients directly.

This reference is an editorial planning draft. Opening hours, prices, transport schedules and reservations require current verification. Read linked sources before committing to bookings.

Beijing

Beijing / North



Imperial stories, lived one hutong at a time.

Beijing rewards a neighbourhood-by-neighbourhood approach. Imperial courtyards occupy enormous blocks; the quieter pleasures are in hutong lanes, lakeside paths and breakfast shops between them. Keep the Great Wall on a separate day and resist crossing the city for every meal.

SUGGESTED STAY 4-5 days

WHEN TO GO April-May · September-October

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BEIJING

Places worth your time.

A CLOSER LOOK

Temple of Heaven

Beijing / Beijing

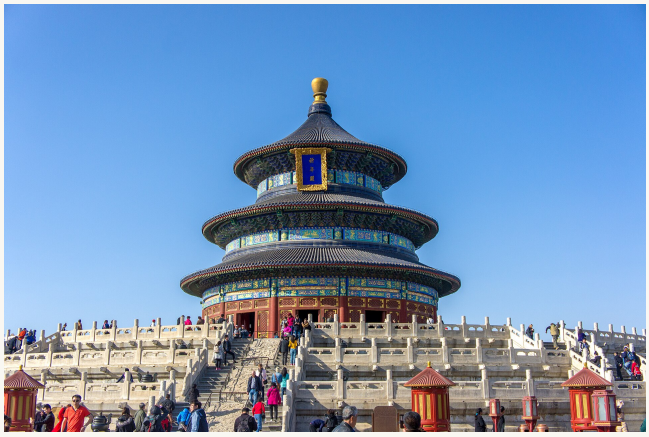


Photo: Shujianyang | CC BY-SA 4.0

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A starting collection, not a single-day checklist. Dedicated outings need their own travel time.

01 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Forbidden City

Give the palace a full morning and leave time for the galleries, not just the central axis.

Find on map

02 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Temple of Heaven

Walk through the park before exploring the ceremonial architecture.

Find on map

03 / DEDICATED OUTING

Mutianyu Great Wall

Make this a separate day trip, with transport back to the city arranged in advance.

Find on map

BEIJING / CONTINUED

Places worth your time.

04 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Summer Palace

Lakeside paths, painted corridors and palace gardens northwest of the centre. Give this an unhurried half-day; the grounds involve substantial walking.

Find on map

05 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Jingshan Park

Climb the central hill for a view over the Forbidden City roofs. A useful short stop after the palace, with steps to the viewpoint.

Find on map

06 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Beihai Park

A lake, white stupa and garden pavilions west of Jingshan. Choose it for a gentler park afternoon rather than another museum.

Find on map

07 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Shichahai hutongs

Explore the lanes behind the lakes, then pause for tea. These remain residential streets: keep doorways clear and ask before photographing people.

Find on map

08 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

798 Art District

Former industrial buildings now house galleries and design shops. Browse a few exhibitions rather than expecting one single-ticket attraction.

Find on map

BEIJING

At the table. Where to stay.

WHAT TO EAT

Peking duck

Order roast duck with pancakes, scallions and sauce; a shared meal makes more sense than a quick solo snack.

WHAT TO EAT

Zhajiangmian

Wheat noodles with savoury bean sauce and vegetable toppings. A practical lunch between sights; meat is common in the sauce.

WHAT TO EAT

Beijing breakfast

Try sesame flatbreads or jianbing from a busy breakfast shop. Huguosi is a useful area to explore traditional snacks.

YOUR BASE

Wangfujing / Dongsi

Convenient for a first visit and eastern old-city sights; choose a hotel near a metro entrance rather than judging only distance on a map.

YOUR BASE

Gulou / Shichahai

Atmospheric lanes and evening walks, but some courtyard stays have difficult vehicle access and less soundproofing.

BEIJING

The practical chapter.

TRANSPORT

Arriving

Check whether your flight uses Capital or Daxing airport. Railway departures may use Beijing South, West, Chaoyang or another station: save the exact Chinese station name.

TRANSPORT

Getting around

The metro is useful for long hops; explore one hutong district on foot. Large roads and security queues make short map distances misleading.

TRANSPORT

Beyond the centre

Mutianyu, Badaling and the Ming Tombs are outside central Beijing. Choose one main excursion and confirm the return transfer before departure.

TIME WELL SPENT

Old-city day

Build around a confirmed Forbidden City reservation, followed by Jingshan. Leave the late afternoon free for nearby lanes rather than adding the Summer Palace.

TIME WELL SPENT

Extra days

Give the Temple of Heaven and a neighbourhood meal one day; the Summer Palace another half-day; reserve a separate day for your chosen Great Wall section.

SOURCES & UPDATES

Original editorial notes. References accessed 2026-09-25. Confirm current access, reservations and services with operators before booking.

TravelChinaGuide · Overview

TravelChinaGuide · Attractions

TravelChinaGuide · Food

TravelChinaGuide · Transport

Shanghai

Shanghai / East



Old lanes, new horizons, and one remarkable river.

Shanghai is best read at street level before you look down from a tower. Move between the riverfront, tree-lined former concession streets and small local eating places. Pudong and the old city show very different faces; neither needs to be squeezed into a single skyline photograph.

SUGGESTED STAY 3-4 days

WHEN TO GO April-May · October-November

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SHANGHAI

Places worth your time.

A CLOSER LOOK

Shanghai Museum

Shanghai / Shanghai



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A starting collection, not a single-day checklist. Dedicated outings need their own travel time.

01 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

The Bund

Walk the historic waterfront and return after dusk for a different view.

Find on map

02 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Former French Concession

Explore plane-tree streets, independent shops and the architecture around Wukang Road.

Find on map

03 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Shanghai Museum

Choose a museum branch and check the exhibitions before setting aside a half-day.

Find on map

SHANGHAI / CONTINUED

Places worth your time.

04 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Yu Garden

A classical garden in the old city, surrounded by a busy bazaar. Separate time inside the garden from shopping and snacks outside.

Find on map

05 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Shanghai Tower

An elevated view over Pudong and the Huangpu River. Choose a clear day; poor visibility can make a tower visit less rewarding.

Find on map

06 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Jade Buddha Temple

An active Buddhist temple with sculptural and architectural interest. Keep voices low and follow photography instructions inside halls.

Find on map

07 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Suzhou Creek

A riverside walk linking industrial heritage and newer cultural spaces. Pick a short section near your accommodation rather than attempting the whole waterfront.

Find on map

08 / DEDICATED OUTING

Zhujiajiao

A water-town day trip with canals, bridges and narrow lanes. Leave time for the onward transfer from the metro and a relaxed return.

Find on map

SHANGHAI

At the table. Where to stay.

WHAT TO EAT

Xiaolongbao

Small steamed buns holding hot soup, usually pork-based. Let them cool and take a small bite before drinking the broth.

WHAT TO EAT

Shengjianbao

Pan-fried buns with crisp bases and juicy fillings. A filling breakfast or inexpensive lunch rather than a delicate dessert.

WHAT TO EAT

Benbang dishes

Shanghai home-style cooking often uses soy sauce and a little sweetness. Try red-braised pork with vegetables and rice as a shared meal.

YOUR BASE

People's Square / Jing'an

Central metro connections and a wide hotel range. Check whether the room faces a busy road.

YOUR BASE

Xuhui / former concession streets

Good for cafes and walking between meals; allow extra travel time for Pudong airport and attractions across the river.

SHANGHAI

The practical chapter.

TRANSPORT

Arriving

Pudong and Hongqiao are different airports. Hongqiao railway station connects with the airport complex, but terminal transfers still take time.

TRANSPORT

Getting around

Use the metro for cross-city travel and walk within individual neighbourhoods. A ferry can add a river-level perspective when its route suits your plans.

TRANSPORT

Beyond the centre

Zhujiajiao needs its own half-day or longer. Suzhou and Hangzhou work better as deliberately planned rail excursions than last-minute additions.

TIME WELL SPENT

Two contrasting days

Walk the Bund and old city on one day. On another, combine the former concession streets with a museum or gallery chosen for your interests.

TIME WELL SPENT

An extra day

Choose either a Pudong skyline visit in clear weather or a slower Zhujiajiao excursion. Do not plan both around a tightly timed airport departure.

SOURCES & UPDATES

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Guilin

Guangxi / South



Let the river set the pace.

Think of this region as several bases rather than one city. Guilin has urban lakes and caves; Yangshuo has countryside lanes; Xingping has river scenery; Longji is a separate mountain excursion. Where you sleep changes how much of each day you spend in a vehicle.

SUGGESTED STAY 3-4 days

WHEN TO GO April-June · September-October

Photo: xiquinhosilva | CC BY 2.0

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GUILIN

Places worth your time.

A CLOSER LOOK

Yulong River

Guilin / Guangxi



Photo: Qeqertaq | CC BY 3.0

Original photograph & licensing

A starting collection, not a single-day checklist. Dedicated outings need their own travel time.

01 / DEDICATED OUTING

Li River

Choose a river excursion for limestone peaks and changing reflections.

Find on map

02 / DEDICATED OUTING

Yulong River

Base yourself in Yangshuo for quiet rural lanes and river scenery.

Find on map

03 / DEDICATED OUTING

Xingping

Spend time along the riverside and explore beyond the busiest photo stop.

Find on map

GUILIN / CONTINUED

Places worth your time.

04 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Elephant Trunk Hill

The city landmark at the meeting of river and karst scenery. Pair it with a waterfront stroll rather than expecting a remote wilderness experience.

Find on map

05 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Reed Flute Cave

An illuminated limestone cave near Guilin. A useful weather alternative, with artificial lighting rather than an untouched cave expedition.

Find on map

06 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Two Rivers and Four Lakes

Lakeside paths and bridges make an easy urban walk. The evening atmosphere differs from the daytime gardens; a cruise is optional.

Find on map

07 / DEDICATED OUTING

Longji Rice Terraces

A full-day trip or overnight stay from Guilin. Choose a village base and walking route before arranging transport; terraces change with the agricultural season.

Find on map

08 / CITY & LOCAL AREA

Daxu Ancient Town

Old trading streets beside the Li River outside the centre. Combine a gentle lane walk with riverside time rather than treating it as a major hiking day.

Find on map

GUILIN

At the table. Where to stay.

WHAT TO EAT

Guilin rice noodles

A breakfast staple with rice noodles, savoury toppings and pickles. Ask about meat and chilli before mixing everything together.

WHAT TO EAT

Yangshuo beer fish

Fish cooked in a beer-based sauce, commonly shared. Confirm fish size and the total price before ordering.

WHAT TO EAT

Oil tea

A savoury tea-based preparation associated with local communities. Try it alongside snacks; it is quite different from a pot of plain tea.

YOUR BASE

Central Guilin lakes

Practical for an arrival night, urban sightseeing and onward travel; it does not put you in the Yangshuo countryside.

YOUR BASE

Yangshuo / Yulong River

Town offers more dining choices; countryside stays offer quieter scenery but require planned transfers after dinner.

GUILIN

The practical chapter.

TRANSPORT

Arriving

Check whether your ticket says Guilin, Guilin North or Guilin West. Yangshuo railway station is near Xingping, not beside Yangshuo town.

TRANSPORT

Getting around

Use walking for the central lakes and vehicles for separated sights. Around Yangshuo, choose short cycling routes suited to your experience and the road conditions.

TRANSPORT

Beyond the centre

Longji and Yangshuo lie in different directions from Guilin. River activities depend on weather and water conditions; keep an alternative land-based day.

TIME WELL SPENT

A regional introduction

Use an arrival afternoon for Guilin lakes. Move toward Yangshuo for a countryside day and choose one Li River experience rather than repeating similar cruises.

TIME WELL SPENT

With more time

Add Xingping at an unhurried pace, or spend a night at Longji. Avoid adding the terraces between two tightly scheduled transport connections.

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